that it had been ‘scarcely able to move beyond the stage of fundraising’.[5] On the other hand, the Naujawan Bharat Sabha’s ‘events brought together individuals across caste and creed in an attempt to encourage a sort of transgressive sociality’.[6]

The Kakori Conspiracy Case of 1925 is therefore a pivotal event in the freedom movement. Though it is much overlooked, it is of great historical significance because, with many of the HRA’s young leaders now dead, Bhagat Singh found himself in the burning furnace of the revolutionary freedom struggle. This struggle was markedly different from the struggle of Gandhi. It had set its face against communalism. There was no more urgent a task than to forge a strong national unity regardless of race, class or creed. Colonialism had undermined the unity of India’s diverse nation by setting one Indian against another. It was now the priority if the country was to successfully move towards the kind of Independence India deserved. Nothing demonstrates this better than how in 1927, just three days before he was hanged, Ashfaqullah Khan wrote an open letter to his countrymen expressing concern over rising communalism in India. He condemned the Tabligh and Shuddhi movements. Hindus and Muslims had to learn to live together, or they would fail to shake off the bondage of servitude. If they failed in this, it would negatively impact the fight for Independence. His words were unequivocally harsh: ‘It is impossible to purify seven crore Muslims and similarly it is absurd to think that twenty five crore Hindus can be converted to Islam. But yes, it is easy that we all put the chains of slavery around our necks.’[7]

Mahavir Singh too wrote in similar terms to his father as he faced life imprisonment in the Andaman Islands:

> By *Samaj* (Society) I do not mean *Arya Samaj* or any other narrow *Samaj* but a society of common people. This is because these religious societies mean nothing to me due to their myopia. Moreover, I want to keep away from all the religions because they are narrow, self centred and based on injustice and want others also to do the same. What I believe to be of greatest benefit to man and society is the following principle: the human relations should not be based on any distinction of caste, colour, religion or money.[8]